

CHAPTER 2 : HEALTH AND DISEASES

Topic:-

Compose a street-play to increase public awareness about dengue, malaria and swine flu.

Introduction:-

Every year during and after the rainy season, thousands of families across Maharashtra suffer from dangerous fevers like Dengue, Malaria, and Swine Flu. Malaria is caused by the Plasmodium protozoan transmitted through the bite of the female Anopheles mosquito. Dengue is caused by the DEN-1 to 4 virus and is spread by the daytime-biting Aedes aegypti mosquito. Swine Flu is caused by the airborne influenza virus A (H1N1).

While government doctors and municipal corporations issue warnings in newspapers, many citizens still ignore mosquito breeding in flower pots or fail to cover their mouths when coughing. Street theatre (known as '*Nukkad Natak*' or पथनाट्य) is one of the most powerful, engaging, and direct mediums to educate people in public squares, markets, and school gates. In this project, our Class 8 friends composed and enacted a lively street play.

❖ Why Street Plays Work Effectively:-

- They use entertaining dialogues, rhyming songs, and humorous characters.
- They reach ordinary citizens, street vendors, and children who may not read health notices.
- They deliver simple actionable health tips in everyday spoken language.

Aim & Character Distribution:-

Aim: To write, rehearse, and perform an engaging street play titled '*Jaago Grahak, Bhagao Macchar!*' to create public awareness about Dengue, Malaria, and Swine Flu.

❖ Objectives of the Street Play:-

- To inform the public about the exact breeding sites of mosquitoes.
- To explain early warning signs: high fever, eye pain, rash, and breathlessness.
- To urge citizens to consult doctors instead of self-medicating with pills.

❖ Cast of Characters & Props:-

- Student 1 (Narrator / सूत्रधार): Carries a dholak to attract crowds.
- Student 2 (Macchar Raja): Wears black clothes with paper wings and a giant fake needle.
- Student 3 (Swine Flu Virus): Wears a spiky costume with a pig mask.
- Student 4 & 5 (Careless Citizens): Throwing plastic cups and ignoring coolers.
- Student 6 (Smart Student Doctor): Wearing a white lab coat with a stethoscope.

Aedes (Dengue)



Anopheles (Malaria)



H1N1 (Swine Flu)

Clean Action!
Stop All Three

Street Play Script & Scenes:-

The street play was staged in four lively scenes at the local market square:

- **Scene 1: The Drum Roll (ढोलक की थाप):**

Narrator beats the dholak loudly: *'Suno suno bhai suno suno! Dengue, Malaria ko door bhagao, swasth raho aur desh bachao!'* A curious crowd gathers around in a circle.

- **Scene 2: Entry of Macchar Raja:**

Mosquito actor buzzes in with flapping wings: *'Hahaha! I am Macchar Raja. Thank you, careless humans, for leaving dirty coolers, old tyres, and broken coconut shells on your terraces! You make perfect swimming pools for my babies!'*

- **Scene 3: Entry of Swine Flu H1N1:**

Swine Flu actor sneezes dramatically without covering his face: *'Achoo! I spread through the air when you cough openly in crowded buses and trains! Wash your hands or I will give you shivering chills and sore throats!'*

- **Scene 4: The Doctor's Solution:**

The student doctor steps forward: *'Stop right there! We will observe Sunday as DRY DAY! We will empty all coolers, sleep under mosquito nets, wear full-sleeve shirts, and visit clinics immediately if fever occurs!'*



Disease Comparison & Facts Table:-

The reference table below compares the three dangerous illnesses highlighted in our play:

<i>Disease Name</i>	<i>Causative Germ</i>	<i>Vector / Mode of Spread</i>	<i>Characteristic Symptoms</i>	<i>Prevention Taught</i>
Dengue	Dengue Flavivirus (DEN 1-4)	Aedes aegypti mosquito (bites daytime)	Severe eye pain, high fever, low blood platelets	Empty coolers, remove stagnant clean water
Malaria	Plasmodium protozoan	Female Anopheles mosquito (bites dusk/night)	Shivering with high fever, sweating, vomiting	Mosquito nets, sprays, blood test immediately
Swine Flu	Influenza virus A (H1N1)	Air droplets & infected saliva from coughing	Difficulty breathing, sore throat, severe body pain	Wear masks, wash hands, avoid touching face

Scientific Analysis & Discussion:-

Analyzing the biology behind these diseases explains why community action is necessary:

- **Why Dengue Platelets Drop:** Dengue virus attacks bone marrow cells, causing blood platelets to drop sharply from normal (1.5–4.5 lakhs) to below 20,000, creating risks of internal bleeding. Early medical admission is critical.
- **Why Aedes Mosquitoes Breed in Clean Water:** Unlike culex mosquitoes that breed in dirty gutters, Aedes mosquitoes prefer clean domestic water stored in overhead tanks, decorative flower vases, and discarded plastic cups. Hence, clean homes are often at greater risk if water is left uncovered!
- **H1N1 Virus Transmission:** The swine flu virus remains active on metal railings and plastic table surfaces for up to 48 hours. Using alcohol sanitizer inactivates the viral lipid coat instantly.

❖ Why Mosquito Nets Beat Mosquito Coils:-

Burning chemical coils releases toxic smoke harmful to children's lungs. Physical mosquito nets are 100% safe, non-toxic, and chemical-free.

Audience Response & Community Impact:-

We performed our street play at three locations: School Ground, Weekly Vegetable Market, and Bus Stand:

- **Massive Public Attendance:** Over 400 people watched our performances. Shopkeepers and housewives clapped enthusiastically and pledged to inspect their terraces for standing water.
- **Dispelling Myths:** Many people believed papaya leaf juice alone can cure dengue. We explained that while papaya leaf juice may help platelets, consulting a doctor and drinking plenty of fluids is life-saving.
- **Student Leadership:** Performing the play improved our communication skills and made our class proud to serve our locality.

❖ Key Recommendations for Municipalities:-

- Regular biological guppy fish release in public ponds (Guppies eat mosquito larvae!).
- Periodic thermal fogging with pyrethrum during monsoon months.
- Timely cleaning and covering of roadside open drains.

What We Learned & Conclusion:-

- Dengue and Malaria are vector-borne diseases spread by Aedes and Anopheles mosquitoes.
- Swine Flu is an airborne viral respiratory disease prevented by masks and hand washing.
- Observing a weekly 'Dry Day' breaks the mosquito lifecycle and stops monsoon epidemics.
- Street plays are powerful educational tools that can communicate lifesaving science to everyone.

Conclusion:-

Our street play proved that art and science make a winning combination for social change. By staging an entertaining drama about Dengue, Malaria, and Swine Flu, we converted dry textbook facts into actionable health awareness. Preventing epidemic diseases is the shared responsibility of every citizen, and young students can lead the way!

References:-

- Maharashtra State Board Class 8 General Science Textbook (Chapter 2: Health and Diseases).
- National Vector Borne Disease Control Programme (NVBDCP) Guidelines.
- Municipal Corporation Public Health Education Department Flyers.